cannot do. Without such conceptual clarity on the Afghan side, Menon argued, India could do little. Communicating specifics about the nature of the Afghan security forces and their requirements took a long time.

The question, however, remains—why did India not tell Afghanistan what kind of force they 'should' build, instead of waiting to hear from them? Conciliators to the core, Singh and Menon were cautious of not coming across as being intrusive with Kabul. For X, such caution was unwarranted.[144] If anything, X argued, India should have openly communicated to Karzai as to what kind of army Afghanistan needed and provided them the relevant technology to build it. Finally, Obama's 2015 declaration that US troops will remain in Afghanistan (and may even fight on occasion, which they do until today) made it easier for India to supply lethal weapons to Kabul without much concerns about technology disparity or capacity constrains. The ANSF critically required helicopters for close air support (CAS) to effectively counter the Afghan Taliban offensives. By January 2016, under the presidency of Ashraf Ghani, the ANSF inducted the four Mi-25 helicopters supplied by India. Soon after, in 2016, Russia also gave 10,000 AK-47s to Kabul.[145]

Conclusion

His adversaries envied (and detested) his manipulations whereas his allies considered him schizophrenic. But no one doubted that Karzai was the most effective politician in post-2001 Afghanistan. In 2016, when Ghani made failed attempts to reconcile differences with Pakistan, people in Afghanistan began to look at Karzai for leadership as their *rahbar* (leader). Almost every Indian diplomat posted in Afghanistan appreciated Karzai's political acumen even if they saw the political dangers of his manipulative behavior. In his own way, Karzai had reconciled the partisans and the conciliators to a considerable extent. He was an internationally recognised figure whom India could engage with, and not earn the label of being overtly anti-Pakistan. It suited the US that India actively asked Karzai's opponents to accept his authority for the sake of Afghan unity and stability. Given the general international consensus on the need for a Pashtun candidate as president, the political value of non-Pashtun candidates